

Australia keeper-batter Beth Mooney boasts an enviable trophy cabinet — four World titles, a Commonwealth Games gold, three Women's Big Bash League crowns, a Women's National Cricket League title, and two Belinda Clark Awards (given to Australia's best international woman cricketer), among other accolades.

But this success didn't come overnight. "Boring Beth" — as she playfully calls herself — spent much of her early career proving people wrong.

As an eight-year-old playing with boys, she was often stationed at fine leg, a position usually reserved for the weakest fielder. Over time, her skills earned recognition. Later, in the Australian setup, head coach Matthew Mott criticised her fitness levels. Today, she ranks among the squad's endurance leaders, alongside Ellyse Perry.

Her Women's Premier League journey was rocky at first — her debut season was derailed by injury, and her second ended in disappointment as captain, with Gujarat Giants finishing last in both editions. This year, freed from the pressures of leadership, Mooney played a key role in the team's remarkable turnaround, helping the Giants reach the Eliminator for the first time.

Straight talker

At the end of the 2024 WPL, Mooney made her stance on captaincy clear.

"No one really noticed it, but management looked at it a few months later and thought it was probably a bit honest," she told *Sportstar* on the sidelines of the tournament.

"When opportunities come to have that 'C' next to my name, I don't really jump at it too much.

From my point of view, I am 31. I am not going to and don't have a desire to captain Australia. I think I am a bit of a quiet leader, away from the spotlight and making moves behind the scenes."

This season, the Giants handed the captaincy to her compatriot Ashleigh Gardner, and Mooney, as a senior player, supported her with field placements, bowling changes, and crucial runs. Mooney finished as the team's second-highest run-scorer, amassing 237 runs, including an unbeaten 96 against UP Warriorz.

"My focus was solely on getting as many runs on the board as a collective as possible. A 100 for me would have been nice. A 200 in that game would have been nice, but it didn't pan out."

The road less taken

Mooney's approach to batting contrasts sharply with the power-hitting trend dominating modern T20 cricket. Yet, both styles offer a Robert Frost-esque choice in the game's evolution.

"I think I'm flying the flag for strategy and placement in T20 cricket rather than boom and bust everywhere. And it's a tough battle to fight. There's a few people out there who probably think that I should be going a bit quicker earlier or hitting the ball harder earlier or whatever it might be, but sometimes the situation or the conditions just don't allow for that. Certainly, my mindset every time I walk out there is to try and get as many runs as I can as quickly as I can," she explains.

Her numbers back up that philosophy. In a format where anchors are often dismissed as outdated, Mooney remains the glue holding the innings together. Since making her Australia debut in 2016, Mooney has been the most consistent opener despite eight players being tested in the role. She



Numbers game

- **Three Australians came close to WPL's first-ever century:** Georgia Voll (99*), Beth Mooney (96*), and Ellyse Perry (90*).
- **Mooney's strike rate:** 121.55 vs pace, 139.13 vs spin.
- **Dot ball percentage:** 24.6% against spin, 38.6% against pace.
- **Faced more pace due to her top-order role.**

has played 103 matches, scoring a leading 3,274 runs (as of March 21) at a strike rate of 125. She has also carried her bat the most for Australia in T20Is during this period, remaining unbeaten 26 times, with Australia winning 21 of those matches.

"I have to stick to what's worked for me, and that doesn't mean resting on my laurels. I am still evolving, and perhaps what that looks like for me is different from the Grace Harrises and Deandra Dottins of the world. I like the fact that when I walk out to bat, the opposition captain is thinking hard about how she is going to get me out."

Despite her steely exterior, Mooney has noticed a shift in how her batting is perceived. Younger players have started approaching her for advice — something she encourages with an emphasis on tactical awareness.

"Understanding the game and conditions better and knowing your strengths in those scenarios are key. For example, in India, the outfielders are lightning quick, so for a boundary, you only need to hit it on either side of cover really hard or along the ground. It doesn't always have to be that big-risk six.

"When people get fixated on hitting sixes and trying to hit the ball